

Title

Primary Care Intervention and Quality of Life Trajectories in Post-ICU Trauma: One-Year Outcomes

Abstract

We randomized 319 ICU survivors with moderate-to-severe PTSD symptoms to either a brief primary-care-delivered psychological intervention (n = 159) or enhanced usual care (n = 160). The intervention consisted of 4-6 sessions with general practitioners trained in structured exposure techniques. At 12-month follow-up, the intervention group showed greater improvement in health-related quality of life scores (mean improvement 0.071 points on 0-1 quality-of-life scale, 95% CI 0.010-0.132) compared to controls. This difference emerged gradually, with no significant between-group difference at 6 months but substantial divergence by 12 months. PTSD symptom severity decreased more substantially in the intervention group (mean reduction 12.3 points on symptom scale vs 6.8 points, $p = 0.004$). Domain-specific analyses showed significant improvements in anxiety/depression and physical functioning scores in the intervention group. Approximately 58% of the intervention group and 41% of controls reported subjectively meaningful improvements in overall quality of life. The intervention was well-tolerated with high completion rates (78% completed ≥ 3 of 6 planned sessions). These findings suggest that structured primary care interventions may improve long-term quality of life in ICU survivors with PTSD.